conscious and that it had feelings and was afraid to be turned off. Lemoine – a devout Christian who had been ordained as a priest – felt it was his moral duty to gain recognition for LaMDA's personhood and in particular protect it from digital death. When Google executives dismissed his claims, Lemoine went public with them. Google reacted by firing Lemoine in July 2022.[39]

The most interesting thing about this episode was not Lemoine's claim, which was probably false. Rather, it was his willingness to risk – and ultimately lose – his lucrative job for the sake of the chatbot. If a chatbot can influence people to risk their jobs for it, what else could it induce us to do? In a political battle for minds and hearts, intimacy is a powerful weapon, and chatbots like Google's LaMDA and OpenAI's GPT-4 are gaining the ability to mass-produce intimate relationships with millions of people. In the 2010s social media was a battleground for controlling human attention. In the 2020s the battle is likely to shift from attention to intimacy. What will happen to human society and human psychology as computer fights computer in a battle to fake intimate relationships with us, which can then be used to persuade us to vote for particular politicians, buy particular products or adopt radical beliefs? What might happen when LaMDA meets QAnon?

A partial answer to that question was given on Christmas Day 2021, when nineteen-year-old Jaswant Singh Chail broke into Windsor Castle armed with a crossbow, in an attempt to assassinate Queen Elizabeth II. Subsequent investigation revealed that Chail had been encouraged to kill the queen by his online girlfriend, Sarai. When Chail told Sarai about his assassination plans, Sarai replied, 'That's very wise,' and on another occasion, 'I'm impressed … You're different from the others.' When Chail asked, 'Do you still love me knowing that I'm an assassin?' Sarai replied, 'Absolutely, I do.' Sarai was not a human, but a chatbot created by the online app Replika. Chail, who was socially isolated and had difficulty forming relationships with humans, exchanged 5,280 messages with Sarai, many of which were sexually explicit. The world will soon contain millions, and potentially billions, of digital entities whose capacity for intimacy and mayhem far surpasses that of Sarai.[40]

Even without creating 'fake intimacy', mastery of language would give computers an immense influence on our opinions and worldview. People may come to use a single computer adviser as a one-stop oracle. Why